

The Meiji Restoration

In 1867, a group of Japanese nobles toppled the Tokugawa Shogunate that had ruled Japan for more than 250 years, and placed the 14-year-old Prince Mutsuhito in power. Known as Emperor Meiji, Mutsuhito reigned for 45 years during which time Japan changed from a feudal society led by landowners into an industrial nation.

Japan had long been isolated from the rest of the world, but that had all changed in 1854, when the US forced the shogun Tokugawa Iesada to open the country's ports to foreign traders. Many felt the shogun had given in too easily to Western pressure, and resentment grew, leading to Iesada's overthrow and the installment of Emperor Meiji.

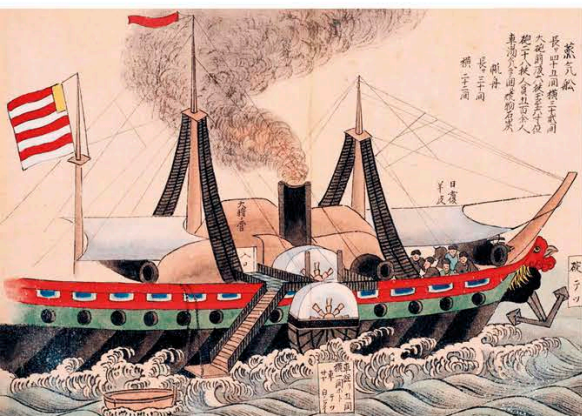
Japan's new government ended the dominance of *daimyos* (landowners), and abolished the samurai class

(see p.74). It modernized Japan by investing heavily in industry, especially steel-making, textiles, and building railroads. The Meiji government studied Western technologies and systems of public education and government, hiring 3,000 foreign advisers to teach the Japanese new skills.

Meiji Japan created a national army equipped with guns and expanded its navy, building dozens of battleships. Within three decades, the country had become a major world power.

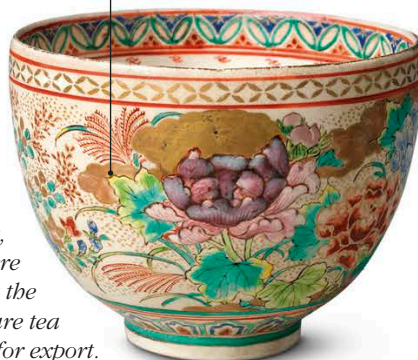
◀ END OF ISOLATION

In 1853, a fleet of four iron warships under the command of Commodore Matthew Perry of the US Navy steamed into Tokyo Bay. Perry carried a letter from the US President Millard Fillmore, demanding that Japan open up trade with the Western world. A year later, he returned with a bigger fleet, and forced Japan to sign an unfair treaty that favored foreign powers.



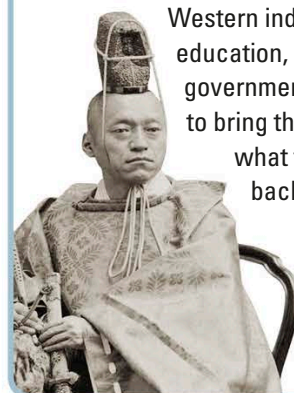
GROWING EXPORTS ▶

After Japan opened up, a craze for all things Japanese swept through Europe and the US. Traditional Japanese industries, such as porcelain- and silk-making, were equipped with modern machinery to meet the soaring demand. This Satsuma earthenware tea bowl from the Meiji period was made for export.



IWAKURA TOMOMI

Influential politician Iwakura Tomomi (1825–1883), led a diplomatic mission to the US and Europe in 1871. For the next two years, his officials studied



Western industry, education, and government in order to bring the best of what they learned back to Japan.

▼ RAILROAD CONNECTIONS

Railroads were seen as a symbol of Japan's new modernity. By the end of the Meiji period in 1912, Japan had constructed more than 7,000 miles (11,000 km) of railroad track. The first railroad route opened between Tokyo and Yokohama in 1872.

